



BEFORE

The vast increase in the population of the United States in the years before the war was driven by mass immigration, mainly of distinct groups of northern Europeans.

EUROPEAN IMMIGRATION

Starting in the 1830s and increasing steadily up to 1861, **thousands of immigrants** from Ireland, Germany, and Scandinavia set sail from their native lands in hope of **a new life in America**. Nearly all of them settled in the **crowded ethnic neighborhoods** of the great northern cities or, taking advantage of Federal land grant incentives, **moved to the frontier** and scratched a living from the soil.

THE FORTY-EIGHTERS

Political émigrés from the **failed Prussian democratic revolutions** of 1848–49, were known as the Forty-Eighters. They fled the area of Europe that is now Germany after the liberal impulse was suppressed by force. In their new home they developed significant **political clout**. Many held radical, even socialist views, most **backed Lincoln** in 1860, and all **hated slavery**.

The U.S. census of 1860 counted over 13 percent of the population as foreign-born. Most of these people lived in New England and the Mid-Atlantic states, and nearly all the rest in the Old Northwest. Fewer than 10 percent resided in the South, mainly because of their inability to compete with slave labor. New York, Philadelphia, Boston, Pittsburgh, Cincinnati, Chicago, and Milwaukee all boasted German, Irish, and Scandinavian-born populations of over 33 percent.

On the eve of secession, New York City was the third-largest German-speaking city in the world. On many city streets in the North storefronts displayed signs in German, and only the German language—or Irish Gaelic—was spoken. In the Midwest, entire rural communities were composed of just Norwegians or Swedes. In the South, immigrants rarely ventured beyond the largest towns. New Orleans, Richmond, and Charleston all had sizeable German and Irish communities, but none exceeded 25 percent of the population.



5 MILLION

The number of European immigrants who came to the United States between 1815 and 1860. By 1860, three-quarters of the foreign-born population were Irish or Germans.

Proving their worth

When the war came, ethnic Americans rallied behind their respective causes like “native-born” Anglo-Americans. But they did